
Mowing-Season Low Back

The May low back — winter-dormant body meets
full-send yard work in one weekend

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Introduction

A BETWEEN-SESSIONS MODULE ON THE MOST predictable injury pattern of the year — and how to prevent it.

Alright, let's talk about your lower back. It's May. You just mowed for three hours after sitting on a couch all winter. I already know what hurts.

Every May my table fills up with the same thing. Low backs that went from winter-dormant to full-send yard work in one weekend. The first warm Saturday hits, the mower comes out of the shed, three hours later you're stretching out a kink that won't quit. Sunday morning you can barely bend down to put on socks. By Monday you're moving like a man twice your age and wondering if this is just what aging feels like.

It isn't. It's a specific, predictable, preventable injury pattern. After 12+ years on the table I've watched this play out the same way every single year.

This module is so you don't have to be that body on my table in May.

CHAPTER 1

Why the transition is dangerous

THE PROBLEM ISN'T MOWING. THE PROBLEM IS the transition from winter-dormant to active.

Through winter, most adults are significantly less physically active than during the rest of the year. Shorter days, colder temperatures, fewer outdoor tasks. The body adapts. Tissue becomes less conditioned to sustained physical work. Hip flexors shorten from increased sitting. Postural muscles weaken. Cardiovascular conditioning drops.

Then spring hits. Suddenly you've got 3-4 hours of mowing on a Saturday. Then garden work Sunday. Then more mowing the next weekend.

Your body, having spent four months in low-output mode, is being asked to deliver high-output performance with no transition period. The tissues that should be loose, conditioned, and ready aren't.

The low back specifically takes the worst of it because:

- Hip flexors shortened over winter pull on the lumbar spine

- The deep stabilizers haven't been activated for sustained work in months
- Hamstrings tight from winter sitting limit the hip hinge needed for safe lifting
- The "core" muscles that should be stabilizing the spine during rotational mower work are dramatically deconditioned

Result: predictable, preventable, painful spring low back lockup.

CHAPTER 2

The muscles involved

WHEN YOU GO TO YOUR PHYSICIAN WITH SPRING low back pain, they often diagnose “muscle strain” without specifying which muscles. Here’s what’s actually happening:

Quadratus lumborum (QL)

Deep muscle running from your last rib down to the top of your pelvis. The QL is heavily involved in side-bending, rotation, and stabilizing the low back during one-sided activities. Mowing — pushing a mower with one hand more than the other, turning constantly — overworks the QL.

When the QL is angry, you’ll feel it as a deep, one-sided pain in your low back, often more on one side than the other. Hurts more when you bend sideways.

Spinal erectors

The long muscles running parallel to your spine on either side. They hold you upright against gravity. During mowing, especially with a push mower on hills, they work hard for sustained periods. When they’re overworked and tight, the back feels stiff and locked — hard to round forward, hard to extend backward.

Hip flexors (psoas, iliacus, rectus femoris)

Already shortened from winter sitting. When you stand up after sitting all winter and immediately do hours of physical work, the shortened hip flexors pull on the lumbar spine constantly during the work. Result: low back compression and that pinch when you stand up after sitting.

Glutes (often underused)

Here's the cruel part — the glutes, which are supposed to be your primary movement muscles for things like lifting and hip extension, are usually weakened from winter inactivity. The result is that low back muscles get recruited to do work the glutes should have been doing. The low back fatigues and locks up while the glutes stay underutilized.

Most spring low back issues are really a glute-not-firing problem masquerading as a low back problem.

CHAPTER 3

Pre-mowing warm-up — 3 minutes that save you 3 days of pain

BEFORE YOU START THE MOWER, DO THIS. EVERY time. The 3 minutes you invest here saves you days of recovery.

1. Cat-cow on hands and knees (45 seconds)

Hands and knees on the floor (or the porch — doesn't matter). 10 slow reps of cat-cow.

This wakes up the entire spinal column and brings blood flow to all the muscles you're about to ask to work.

2. Standing hip flexor lunge (60 seconds)

Step into a lunge with right foot forward, left knee bent down. Squeeze the back-side glute. Push the hip forward gently. Hold 30 seconds.

Switch sides. 30 seconds.

This addresses the shortened hip flexors before they pull on your lumbar spine during the mow.

3. Glute activation (45 seconds)

Stand. Squeeze your glutes hard for 5 seconds. Release. Repeat 10 times.

Sounds silly. Works. You're literally turning on the muscles that should be doing the work, before the work starts. This is the single most-skipped warm-up move and the one that prevents the most pain.

4. Spinal twist standing (30 seconds)

Stand tall. Hands on hips. Rotate slowly to the right as far as comfortable. Pause. Rotate to the left. 5 reps each direction.

This wakes up rotational range of motion you'll need during the mowing pattern.

Total: 3 minutes. Don't skip it just because it feels unnecessary. The unnecessary feeling is exactly why most people end up on my table in mid-May.

CHAPTER 4

Post-mowing protocol — first 30 minutes after you come inside

I COVERED THE IMMEDIATE-RECOVERY PROTOCOL in detail in B5 (Post-Mowing Recovery) — if you're a Between Sessions member, that's your companion piece. For everyone, here's the abbreviated version:

The 30 minutes after you come inside are the highest-leverage recovery window of the entire mowing day.

Step 1 — Walk it off (2 min): Don't collapse on the couch. Walk around for 2 minutes.

Step 2 — Water with salt: Replace electrolytes. One glass.

Step 3 — Hip flexor lunge (1 min): 30 seconds each side. Address what got shortened.

Step 4 — Forward fold and spinal decompression (3 min): Stand and hang forward for 30 seconds. Then lie flat on the floor for 2 minutes.

That's ~6-7 minutes. The difference between sore-but-functional tomorrow and wrecked-and-limping.

CHAPTER 5

When it's normal soreness vs. when it's something you should get checked

THIS MATTERS. NOT ALL SPRING BACK PAIN IS the same. Some is benign muscle soreness that resolves with the protocols. Some warrants a doctor.

Normal mowing-day soreness (resolves with rest + protocols):

- Generalized stiffness in the low back, both sides
- Worse in morning, eases as you move around
- Improves over 2-4 days
- Pain stays in the back — doesn't shoot anywhere else
- Can still bend forward (even if it's stiff)

Get it looked at:

- Sharp, shooting pain down one leg (sciatic nerve involvement)

- Numbness or tingling anywhere in legs or feet
- Weakness in legs (foot drop, can't push off properly)
- Bladder or bowel function changes — this is urgent, ER-level
- Pain that doesn't improve at all over 5-7 days
- Pain that gets worse, not better
- Sudden severe pain during the activity (something popped or tore)

The first list is mowing. The second list is potentially a disc issue, nerve compression, or other structural problem. Don't try to stretch through the second list. Get it evaluated.

CHAPTER 6

Why this happens every year (and how to break the cycle)

MOST PEOPLE WHO GET THE MAY LOW BACK lockup get it every May. Same person, same pattern, same April-to-May spike in body complaints. Year after year.

The reason: they don't make any changes in the off-season that would condition them differently.

The fix is not “mow less” — that's not realistic. The fix is “be slightly less deconditioned by April.”

That means:

- Some movement throughout winter, even if minimal (the morning unlock from B1 is plenty)
- Some hip flexor and core work in March-April as the weather turns (use M9 Hips and Hip Flexors module)
- Conscious warm-up before the FIRST mow of the season, not the third
- Conscious recovery after every mow, not just the bad ones

Do these things and the May lockup pattern breaks. You'll still be sore after a hard mow — but it'll be "sore" not "I can't move."

CHAPTER 7

A note on age

I SEE THIS PATTERN HIT HARDER IN 40S AND BEYOND. Younger bodies recover more automatically. After 40, the cumulative effect of “winter dormant, spring full-send” compounds faster.

This isn’t pessimism — it’s just biology. The same fix works at any age. It just becomes more important to actually do it as the years pass.

If you’re in your 40s, 50s, 60s and you’ve been the May lockup person for years, this is the year to break the pattern. Three minutes before. Six minutes after. Every mow. All season.

CHAPTER 8

When to come see me

IF YOU'VE ALREADY HAD THE LOCKUP THIS spring — book a session. We'll release what's compressed and get you mobile faster than home recovery alone.

If you haven't had the lockup yet — book a preventive session in early May. We'll address whatever winter tightness has accumulated before the mowing season hits its peak. Much better than reactive sessions in June.

The math: one preventive session in May tends to replace 2-3 reactive sessions in June and July. Cheaper, less painful, more effective.

CHAPTER 9

Closing

THREE MINUTES BEFORE, FIVE MINUTES AFTER. That's the deal. Your back will thank you by August.

The May low back pattern is the most predictable injury in my practice. It's also one of the most preventable. The cost of doing the warm-up and recovery is small. The cost of skipping them is days of lost function multiple times per spring.

Start with the next mow. The very next time. Set a timer if you need to. Three minutes warm-up before the mower starts. Six minutes recovery within 30 minutes of coming inside. That's the whole prescription.

The companion workbook has a pre-mowing self-check, a mowing season tracker, and three reflection prompts to help you notice your own pattern and break it.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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